

and was working with an inner-city planning commission.

During the next five years, Ben and Mary were responsible for organizing other middle- and upper-income families to raise funds for urban renewal. To date, they have refurbished over 100 run-down homes with totally private funds and given or sold them (at no interest) to low-income families, particularly elderly people. Because Ben and Mary chose to live God's plan for their lives, several city officials came to know Jesus Christ as Saviour and have become staunch allies of Christianity where they were openly hostile previously.

Perhaps God wants to teach us to trust Him, or to endure maximum suffering and get along without all the trinkets and toys our generation strives after. At some point, every couple has to ask, "What is God's plan for us?" That's why it's so important for a husband and wife to communicate about money, because together you can reach a better balance.

One counselee thought his wife was the biggest spendthrift in the world. He was afraid she would spend all their money if she had access to it. So he managed their budget with little or no input from her. It was an area of real friction because she felt as if she were being treated like a child (which she was). Then God put this man under conviction that he needed to change his attitude. As it says in 1 Peter 3:7, "You husbands likewise, live with your wives in an understanding way, as with a weaker vessel, since she is a woman; and grant her honor as a fellow heir of the grace of life, so that your prayers may not be hindered." This admonition is pretty stern. If you don't treat your wife as your fellow heir (partner), God will not answer your prayers. So this man's choice was: "Do I treat my wife as my partner or go through life with muted prayers?" With great fear and trepidation, he turned all the finances over to his wife. He let her write the checks, balance the checkbook, and pay the bills. Do you know what he discovered? His wife was twice as cheap as he ever was and a better bookkeeper too. He opened the greatest area of communications they had ever known and learned that God had put his wife in his life as a helpmate.